

A FREE TABLE · LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

NOBODY CLEANS UP AFTER A WIZARD

100 things magic leaves behind, and who is still living with them.

System-agnostic · no prep · 5e-compatible (SRD 5.1) · free to use under CC BY 4.0

THE HOOK

The duel ends. The ritual works. The war is signed away in a tent somewhere and the people who did the casting go home or go into the ground. Nothing else goes back. The bread in that village will not stale. The dogs will not walk down that street. There is a room in that manor that is exactly the temperature of the last person who was happy in it. Nobody sends anyone to fix that. There is no department. The people who live there just learn the rules and stop mentioning them to visitors.

This is a table of those rules.

AT A GLANCE

What it is. A d100 of magical residue, plus a d10 of who is still paying for it.

Who it is for. Any GM who needs a place to feel used, not decorated.

System. None required. There is not a stat block or a saving throw in the whole thing. Runs in 5e, in an OSR game, in anything with a die.

Prep time. None. Roll one on the walk to the table.

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THREE WAYS TO SPEND A ROLL

As dressing. Read the row, put it in the room, never explain it. A world where small things are wrong without a plot attached is a world the players believe in. Most rolls should be this. Resist the urge to make every one of them a quest.

As a thread. Pull on the row until it names a person. Who benefits? Who has arranged their life around it? Who is quietly the reason it has not been fixed? The d10 on the last page does this part for you. A residue with a face on it is an adventure hook that took nine seconds to make.

As a price. Hand the party a spell, a favor, or a shortcut, and tell them the row is what it costs the place they cast it in. Nothing hurts a table like the third session in a village that is still living with what the party did in the first.

Roll twice and combine when you want a location that has been fought over more than once. Two residues in the same building do not blend. They argue. A GM can get a whole session out of the seam between them.



WHAT THE MAGIC LEFT

D100 WHAT IS STILL WRONG HERE

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | Every candle in the house burns down to exactly the same length by morning, no matter when it was lit. The wax pools in a shape somebody in the family recognizes. |
| 2 | Fire in this room gives light but no heat. The cook has been serving cold bread for a year and telling nobody why. |
| 3 | Shadows in the taproom fall toward the door instead of away from the lamp. The regulars all sit facing it now and could not tell you when they started. |
| 4 | A lantern hung on the fourth hook of the bridge will not go out in any wind, and will not come down for any hand but a child's. |
| 5 | Sunlight through the chapel's east window arrives about a minute late. The priest has quietly moved every service back to match it. |
| 6 | Anything set on the hearthstone throws the shadow of what it used to be. The chair shows a sapling. The ring shows a hand. |

D100 WHAT IS STILL WRONG HERE

- 7 The forge fire burns green on the day someone in the village is going to die. The smith stopped announcing it, because people started asking him to check before journeys.
- 8 Nothing in the cellar casts a shadow. Two men have gone down and come back certain they were followed, and neither of them was wrong.
- 9 One window in the row is lit every night from inside an empty room, and the landlord collects rent on it.
- 10 Snuffed candles in this street relight after a count of ten. The nightwatch carries a bucket of sand instead of a snuffer.
- 11 The well repeats what you say into it about six hours later, at full volume, to whoever happens to be standing there. Half the village's secrets came out this way.
- 12 Every bell in town rings a half tone flat and has since the war. Travelling musicians cannot play here and cannot explain why.
- 13 There is one flagstone in the square you cannot speak a lie while standing on. The magistrate knows which one. Nobody else does.
- 14 The mill wheel makes a sound like a held breath before it turns. The workers have started timing their prayers to it.
- 15 Footsteps in the upper hall arrive about three seconds before the person does. The household always knows who is coming and never mentions it to guests.
- 16 Whistling is impossible inside the walls. Air goes through pursed lips and comes out as one word in a language nobody here speaks.
- 17 A room where no sound carries out and none carries in. The innkeeper rents it to people who pay double and asks them nothing.
- 18 The last word of any argument held in this kitchen is audible again the next morning, once, in the voice that said it.
- 19 Dogs in the lower ward start barking at the same moment every night, at nothing, and stop at the same moment. You can set a watch by it.
- 20 Sing in the ruined tower and something takes the harmony. It is polite about it. It has been getting closer to the melody every year.
- 21 Bread baked here does not stale. It also does not fill anyone. A family of six is starving at a full table.
- 22 Wine from the third barrel tastes like whatever the drinker most regrets. The tavern keeper has made a quiet fortune out of what people say next.
- 23 The stream runs clean, and anything washed in it comes out clean of more than dirt. A murderer's shirt came back white, and so did his memory of that night.
- 24 Salt will not dissolve in water inside the town limits. Curing meat works. Making broth does not. Somebody has worked out what else that is good for.
- 25 Every apple from the orchard's north row has one seed shaped like a tooth. They grow, if you plant them.
- 26 Milk sours the instant it crosses the old boundary stone. The dairy can sell inside it and cannot expand past it, and a stranger has offered to buy the field.
- 27 Water drawn at night comes up warm and water drawn at noon comes up near freezing. The bathhouse runs backward and does good business.
- 28 A pot on this stove will boil, but it takes exactly as long as the cook's patience allows. Calm cooks eat late. Angry ones burn everything.
- 29 Cheese in the ripening cave ages a season in a week. So does anything else left in there, including the boy who fell asleep in it.
- 30 Anything fermented in this cellar comes out remembering the last hands that touched it, and it will not pour for a stranger.
- 31 Cats will not enter the east wing. They sit at the threshold and watch one spot near the ceiling until somebody carries them away.

D100 WHAT IS STILL WRONG HERE

- 32 The crows here have learned one human word and use it correctly. Nobody in the village wants to be the one to tell you which word.
- 33 Horses passing the crossroads shy left. Every horse, every time, for two hundred years. There is nothing on the left. There used to be.
- 34 The bees make comb in the shape of letters. Read enough of it across enough hives and you have most of a name.
- 35 Every dog born in the village has the same white mark, and the mark has been getting larger with each generation.
- 36 Fish pulled from the pond are already gutted, cleanly, and the innards are never found. The fishwives call it a blessing and do not eat them.
- 37 Mice avoid the granary and nest in the chapel instead. The priest stopped setting traps because of what he found in one.
- 38 A single sparrow follows anyone who lies inside the walls, at a polite distance, until they tell the truth or leave the parish.
- 39 The sheep on the high pasture all face the same way at dusk, and it is not the way to the fold.
- 40 Insects will not cross the doorway of the burned house. It is the only place in the valley without flies and the only place nobody will sleep.
- 41 One door in the hall opens onto the hall. Walk through it and you are briefly behind yourself, watching what you were doing.
- 42 The stair has thirteen steps going up and twelve coming down. The missing one is where the tutor was standing.
- 43 A room that stays at the temperature of the last person who was happy in it, which is why the family keeps finding reasons to check the nursery.
- 44 Locks in this house open for anyone who is genuinely lost and for nobody who is looking for something.
- 45 The cellar door cannot be opened while anyone is watching it. This has never once been a convenience.
- 46 A hallway with a window at the end showing a garden that cannot be found from outside. Two servants have climbed through and come back wet.
- 47 Chalk lines drawn on the workshop floor stay until the work is finished. The last apprentice's lines are still there.
- 48 Any room this door opens into has one more chair in it than there were people. The extra one is always warm.
- 49 The threshold stone remembers weight. Cross it and a small settling sound tells you whether you are heavier than you were last time.
- 50 A guest room where the bed is made by morning whether or not it was slept in, and the pillow always holds a shape.
- 51 Graves in the north corner will not hold a marker. The stones sink a hand's width a year. The sexton keeps a ledger of what is really down there.
- 52 The dead here do not rot and do not rise. They keep. The family crypt is a century of relatives with their eyes closed and their color good.
- 53 Speak a dead person's full name in the churchyard and one bell rings. It has rung six times this week and nobody will admit to talking.
- 54 The ossuary bones are warm. They have been warm since the siege. The bishop's entire answer to this is a stronger lock.
- 55 Flowers left on any grave move overnight to the next grave along, always the same direction, and the last grave in the row is buried in them.
- 56 Anyone buried here turns up in the wrong grave within a year. Not moved, not disturbed. Just wrong. The parish has stopped digging to check.
- 57 The war dead were burned in one pit and the smoke has not finished. It still comes up thin out of the ground when the weather turns.

D100 WHAT IS STILL WRONG HERE

- 58** Tell a lie over the tomb and the effigy's folded hands open. The knight's hands have been open for six years and his family is quietly frantic.
- 59** Grass grows fastest over the newest grave and not at all over the oldest. You can date the entire yard by looking at it.
- 60** A pauper's field where every skull was found facing the manor house. The current lord has heard the story and has not gone to look.
- 61** Every clock in the district runs true except for four minutes lost between midnight and dawn. Nobody has found where the four minutes go.
- 62** Market day comes twice in some weeks and the town works it out a day too late. No ledger here has balanced in years, and the tax collector is due.
- 63** There is one day a year nobody in town can remember afterward. They wake with the work done and the bread eaten and the day gone.
- 64** Count the pillars of the ruin and you get a different number each time. The number is always the age of whoever is counting.
- 65** The hourglass in the guildhall runs slow while anyone in the building is lying. The guildmaster has built his whole method on it.
- 66** A stretch of road that takes an hour going and ten minutes coming back. Merchants plan around it. Nobody has walked it at night twice.
- 67** The sundial reads true at noon and reads nonsense the rest of the day, but the nonsense repeats on a cycle, and the cycle is a date.
- 68** The harvest festival has fallen on the same calendar day for a century, and for twelve years running it has landed on a different day of the week. That is not possible.
- 69** Wounds taken inside the old keep heal at whatever speed the keep decides, which is fast for the patient and slow for the impatient.
- 70** Anything left in the tower room overnight comes out with a year of dust on it. Anything left for a year comes out clean.
- 71** Nobody born here can be woken once they are properly asleep. Not by shouting, not by shaking, not by smoke. The village keeps a rota of outsiders who stay up.
- 72** Everyone in the village has the same small scar in the same place on the left palm, and not one of them remembers getting it.
- 73** Cut yourself inside the walls and the blood runs uphill along the skin before it falls. The barbers charge extra and earn it.
- 74** Twins are born in this valley at nine times the ordinary rate, and one of each pair is always left handed. The midwife keeps a list and will not say why.
- 75** Speak above a whisper in the long gallery and your voice comes out as your father's. Men who never knew their fathers learn something here.
- 76** Hair cut in this house grows back overnight to the same length, forever. The barber is rich and the wigmaker is ruined.
- 77** Everyone who sleeps in the manor has the same dream: a room, a chair, and a person just out of sight who is about to turn around.
- 78** People here cannot lie about their age. They can try. What comes out is the true number, in a flat voice they do not control.
- 79** A birthmark shaped like a key runs in one family, and the shape has changed slowly over four generations. It is nearly a different key now.
- 80** Every mirror in town runs a half second behind. Long enough to notice. Long enough to watch yourself finish a movement you already stopped making.
- 81** Rain falls on the field and not on the path, along a line so clean the farmer ploughs to it.
- 82** Nothing has grown in the crater in thirty years, and the ring of grass around it grows tall enough to hide a standing man.

D100 WHAT IS STILL WRONG HERE

- 83** Frost forms on the inside of the windows in high summer, in the same pattern every time, and the pattern is a floor plan.
- 84** Lightning has struck the same oak eleven times. It is still alive, still leafing, and the wood will not burn.
- 85** The wind through the pass carries the smell of a kitchen: onions, fat, woodsmoke. There has been no kitchen up there since the war.
- 86** Snow does not settle on one square of the courtyard, and the square is about the size of a body.
- 87** Every plant in the walled garden grows toward the well instead of the sun, and the gardener has begun finding reasons not to draw from it.
- 88** Dig anywhere in the lower field and you hit ash at two feet, wherever you dig, and no record in the parish says why.
- 89** Fog here rolls in from inland and goes out to sea, which is backward, and it comes on the day of a death every time.
- 90** The moss on the standing stones is warm to the touch and grows only on the side facing the village.
- 91** Coins minted before the war will not stay in a purse in this town. They turn up in the poor box by morning, all of them, every time.
- 92** Ink in the guild ledger fades over exactly one year, so the guild's entire recorded history is a rolling twelve months and everyone has agreed not to discuss it.
- 93** Any contract signed in this room holds harder than law. Not enforced by anything anyone can point to. Just never once broken, and the four who tried died of ordinary causes.
- 94** The parish register carries entries in a hand nobody recognizes, recording births that have not happened yet. The last one is dated next month.
- 95** Letters posted from the village arrive opened and resealed, in better handwriting, with the meanness taken out.
- 96** Debts written in charcoal on the tavern wall cannot be rubbed out until they are paid. One line has been there since before the current owner was born.
- 97** Silver tarnishes black overnight inside the walls, so the whole town trades in copper and the rich have learned to look poor.
- 98** A page torn from any book in the library is back in the book by morning, and the reader cannot recall a word of what was on it.
- 99** The tax rolls list one household no living person can find. It has paid on time and in full for sixty years.
- 100** Every signature on the old treaty has faded but one, and that one is getting darker.

AND WHO IS STILL PAYING FOR IT

Roll this when a residue needs a face. This is the row that turns dressing into an adventure.

ROLL FOR A FACE

D10 WHO IS LIVING WITH IT

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | The person who caused it. Still alive, still local, still respected, has never told a soul, and walks out to check on it every week. |
| 2 | A child born afterward, who has grown up assuming this is how the world works everywhere and is going to be badly surprised by their first journey. |
| 3 | The family who own the ground. They make their living off it and will fight anyone who comes to put it right. |
| 4 | A scholar who came to study it, stayed, and has published nothing in eleven years, because publishing means somebody arrives to fix it. |
| 5 | The person it was aimed at. They survived. They will not say what it was supposed to do to them. |
| 6 | Nobody living. The last one who understood it died two winters back and left written instructions that were burned by mistake. |
| 7 | The whole village, through a small payment nobody calls a tax, made to a person nobody calls a priest. |
| 8 | An outsider who bought the property cheap, knew exactly what they were buying, and is waiting for something none of the neighbors have worked out. |
| 9 | The one who was supposed to be maintaining it. They stopped six months ago. It has not gone wrong yet. |
| 10 | A rival who did not cause it and keeps it going anyway, because the town's problem is the rival's leverage. |

ONE NOTE BEFORE YOU ROLL

Residue is not a puzzle by default. Most of these should never be solved, because a world where every strange thing has an answer waiting is a world with no weather in it. Let the players notice. Let them ask. Let the villagers give the shrug of people who stopped asking a long time ago.

Then, once a session, pick one and put a name on it.



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Compatible with fifth edition and with any game you can roll a die in. Portions of the underlying system reference: SRD 5.1, CC BY 4.0.
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